

Being and Nothingness



Although he started his career as teacher of philosophy, Jean-Paul Sartre soon became better known as a novelist and playwright. In both literary and philosophical work, however, he explored the ideas of Kierkegaard and Nietzsche concerning freedom to choose value systems and finding meaning in life. His most important philosophical book, *Being and Nothingness* (1943), was also influenced by the phenomenology of Husserl and Heidegger. In it, he explains that we have not been created by a god for a purpose, so we have to create our own purpose in life. By making our own rules and value system, we can determine for ourselves what sort of life we

will lead and effectively create ourselves. Existence, he says, precedes essence; first we exist, next we encounter ourselves and experience 'existential angst', then we can create our own essence. It is our choice to do this, and live to the full, or simply accept existing values. Sartre later became involved in communist politics and modified his existentialist views to say that we can never completely free ourselves from the values of society.